▶ MAHARASHTRA

THE 'LOK TANTRIKS'



Politics is a high-stress profession in these turbulent, uncertain times. So its frazzled practitioners have enough reason to seek divine benediction. The grapevine has it that an Opposition satrap in Maharashtra favours the voodoo powers of a Bengali tantrik and doesn't think twice before even washing his feet. A leading figure in the government, who has much at stake, leans towards the Mother Goddess—again with a touch of tantrism. During the June 2022 split in the Shiv Sena, Chief Minister **Eknath Shinde** and his band of fugitive rebels had famously sought blessings at Assam's Kamakhya temple. Goddess Bagalamukhi had been the one to be invoked by a BJP politico in 2019, when the original saffron parivar split. Marathwada politicians apparently propitiate Lord Kuber, the giver of wealth, at a temple in a nearby state. We are in no doubt that they want to set right India's rank on the World Inequality Index. ■

▶ KARNATAKA

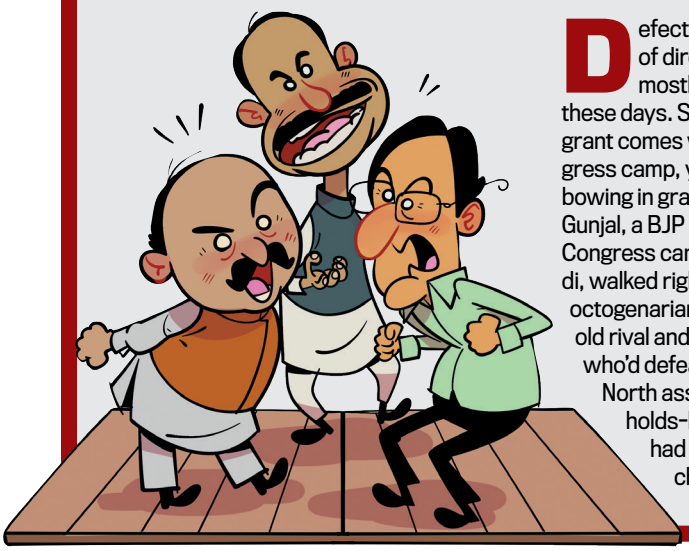
MINI MANTRIS

In military terms, the Congress has earned the right to see Karnataka as a position of advantage—a high Deccan spur castle from which it can easily pick out any invading horde. Home to the stentorian party boss Mallikarjun Kharge and to the two redoubtable kshatrapas Siddaramaiah and D.K. Shivakumar, both as scrappy and canny as you want, you'd think they would go all guns blazing. Yes, the GOP's set target is to win 20 out of the state's 28 constituencies. But strangely, a touch of pusillanimity is



▶ RAJASTHAN

R.I.P., OR 'OM SHANTI'?



Defectors have a sense of direction: their GPS is mostly set saffronward these days. So, when a stray migrant comes walking into the Congress camp, you'd expect it to be bowing in gratitude. But Prahlad Gunjal, a BJP import named the Congress candidate for Kota-Bundi, walked right into the grizzled octogenarian Shanti Dhariwal—his old rival and ex-cabinet minister who'd defeated him in the Kota North assembly seat. A no-holds-barred battle, Gunjal had raked up corruption charges on Dhariwal's Rs 5,500 crore Kota beautification plan. Dhariwal still feels those poison wasp-stings. So, yoked together on one stage for a party programme on March 29, sparks flew. Dhariwal demanded an apology! And, incredibly, hurled the "communal" tag at Gunjal. Their supporters separated like curd from whey and hurled slogans at each other. Gunjal's boys felt Dhariwal was sneakily trying to help frenemy Om Birla, also in the fray. The LS speaker, also a Kota native, is an old bugbear for Gunjal who he feels torpedoed his chances in the assembly polls. As for Dhariwal and Birla, they're seen to be so thick that they're called 'Om-Shanti'. ■

Illustrations by **SIDDHANT JUMDE**